The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter

Around 9,000 people in **Gaza** need to be evacuated for lifesaving medical care abroad, the World Health Organisation said. In recent days there has been intense fighting around al-Shifa hospital, one of few in the enclave to remain somewhat open. Separately an official from America's State Department told Reuters that famine might already be "present" in some areas of northern Gaza.

Israel's High Court ordered a freeze on funding for religious institutions whose **ultra-Orthodox** students have not registered for military service despite being eligible for conscription. The ruling intensifies the in-fighting in the coalition government over whether young *Haredi* men should be obliged to fight. Ultra-Orthodox parties want to codify an exemption in law, which many Israelis and some in the coalition government oppose.

Jerome Powell, the head of the **Federal Reserve**, said that he expects inflation to fall, just hours after the personal-consumption-expenditures index (the Fed's preferred measure of inflation) showed it had risen by 0.1 percentage points to 2.5% in February. Mr Powell said that, though the road was "sometimes bumpy", inflation was heading towards the central bank's target of 2%.

Donald Tusk, **Poland's** prime minister, said **Europe** is entering a "pre-war era" and urged European countries to increase defence spending. Mr Tusk also called for more military aid for Ukraine in its war against Russia as the next two years would "decide everything". The comments came days after Russia launched an aerial assault on Ukraine's energy infrastructure.

Somalia's parliament took a first step towards abolishing the country's clan-based voting system in favour of **universal**

suffrage. Lawmakers unanimously approved changes to four of the 15 chapters of the constitution affected. Once they have voted on the rest, the changes will be subject to a public vote. Somalia has not had universal suffrage since 1969. Several former presidents and prime ministers oppose it.

Syngenta, a Swiss pesticides firm, cancelled plans to float on the Shanghai Stock Exchange amid a prolonged rout in Chinese stockmarkets. Bought by state-owned ChemChina in 2017, Syngenta had planned to raise about $9bn, at a valuation nearing $60bn, but had postponed its IPO several times since 2021. The firm said it would seek to list in China or elsewhere once conditions improve.

Cambridge University beat Oxford in both the women's and the men's annual **boat races**. Since 2000 Oxford has notched 13 wins in the men's race, and Cambridge 11. One member of Oxford's team said that some of his crew had suffered illness caused by E. coli. In recent days rowers had been warned against entering the River Thames after high levels of the bacteria were found in the water, linked to sewage discharges by water utilities.

Word of the week: *Le dry January*, a phrase that has recently entered France's national lexicon. Read the full story.

Photo: Getty Images

Palestinians commemorate Land Day

On Saturday Israeli-Arabs, as Palestinian citizens of Israel are known, mark Land Day. In 1976 they organised marches and strikes after the government moved to expropriate swathes of land in Israel—some of which was Arab-owned. Six were shot dead by Israel's army and police.

This year's commemoration comes amid harrowing scenes from Gaza. And new hardships in the occupied West Bank add to the misery. Settler violence has increased dramatically, threatening lives and livelihoods. Some Israeli settlers have uprooted olive trees during harvest season, depriving Palestinian families of a source of income. The economy has been crippled by restrictions on Palestinians who used to cross the border to work in Israel.

Dozens of Israeli-Arabs, meanwhile, have been arrested over social-media posts critical of Israel's conduct in Gaza. Though fears of confrontations during Ramadan have not yet materialised, protests on Land Day have in the past led to violent clashes. This year, there is more reason than most for anger.

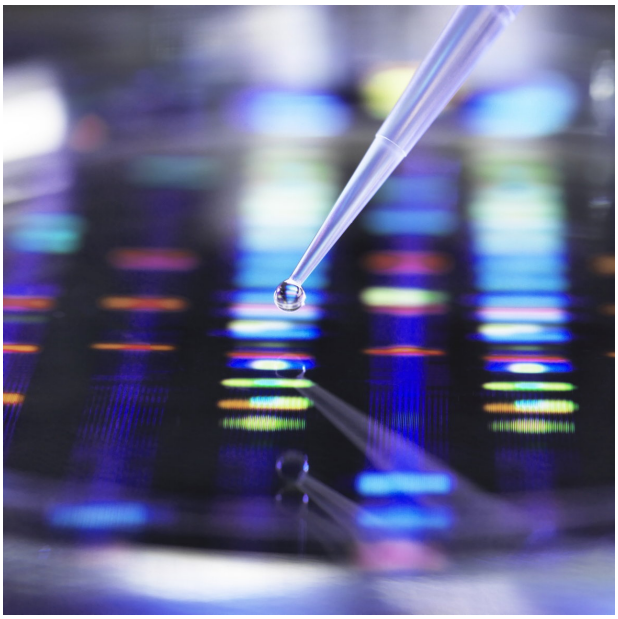


Photo: Getty Images

AI’s health-care potential

Scientists and technology firms have been developing artificial intelligence systems for health care, with some success. AI’s ability to see connections that humans cannot could help with everything from diagnosing diseases to assisting in gene editing and drug development. And it has the potential to make health-care systems more efficient and cost-effective. But progress at integrating these tools remains slow. Recent advances in large language models and generative AI are fostering hope that a new generation of health AIs will soon emerge.

Challenges will abound. LLMs have problems with bias, accuracy, reliability and transparency. AI-powered health tools that use them will need post-sale monitoring to ensure they remain safe and effective once on the market. And proper regulation will require some tricky decisions. But if these tools are widely adopted into systems designed to maximise their potential, the results will improve millions, and maybe billions, of lives.

Photo: Getty Images

Britain’s Boat Race lures foreign talent

For almost 200 years male crews representing the universities of Oxford and Cambridge have competed in an annual boat race. The race, which usually takes place on a 4.2-mile stretch of the Thames in London, was once a showcase of Britain's best young rowing talent. Matthew Pinsent, Tim Foster and Kieran West all took part before going on to win Olympic golds for their country.

Modern editions have a more international flavour. Though crews have only nine people, this year's race, on Saturday, features athletes from America, Australia, Canada, Germany, Ireland, the Netherlands, New Zealand and Poland. The universities know that the contest attracts some of the world's best rowers. But both institutions say that their rowers must win university places on academic merit before they can win a seat in the boat. That the two universities have similar admissions policies meaning there is little distance between them—since 2000 Oxford has notched 13 wins, and Cambridge 11.

Photo: dpa

Will Bayern Munich be dethroned?

The Bundesliga has long been a one-horse race. Bayern Munich have won Germany's top football division for 11 years in a row. But this year the Bavarians may lose their crown. After 26 of the

season's 34 matches Bayern sit ten points behind Bayer 04 Leverkusen, a club from western Germany that is owned by a pharmaceutical company. To stay in the title race Bayern will probably have to beat Borussia Dortmund, historically their greatest rivals, on Saturday. The fixture is known as "Der Klassiker"; no translation needed.

Leverkusen's success stems largely from the talent of Xabi Alonso, their Spanish manager and a former World Cup-winning midfielder. He has introduced an attractive playing style based on retaining possession and short passing. Rumours have been circulating that several top European clubs, including Bayern and Liverpool, wanted to poach him. But on Friday Mr Alonso put them to rest, saying he would stay at Leverkusen.

Photo: Getty Images

Weekend profile: Arvind Kejriwal, Delhi's detained anti-corruption crusader

Arvind Kejriwal claims to be the victim of a stitch-up. On March 21st Delhi's chief minister and the leader of India's opposition Aam Aadmi Party, which runs the capital and the northern state of Punjab, was arrested for allegedly failing to co-operate with an

investigation into kickbacks the AAP supposedly received for alcohol licences.

Mr. Kejriwal protests, arguably with good cause, that Narendra Modi, the prime minister, and his ruling Bharatiya Janata Party are going after him to distract from their own corrupt practice of systematically investigating political opponents. (The BJP denied doing this.) On Saturday supporters of the INDIA Alliance, a 27-party bloc opposed to the BJP, will take to Delhi's streets to demand Mr Kejriwal's release. They want to make sure that one of their most popular leaders is allowed to campaign in India's general election, which starts on April 19th.

It would be grimly ironic if Mr Kejriwal lost his role in public life because of graft allegations. An engineer-turned-civil servant from northern India, the 55-year-old rose to prominence as a rabble-rousing campaigner leading a popular movement against endemic corruption during the Congress-led government that preceded Mr Modi. He founded the AAP on this image. The party's symbol is a broom—symbolising its commitment to sweeping away corruption.

Mr Kejriwal built a reputation for good governance in his ten years-plus as chief minister of Delhi, despite constant attempts by the central government to undermine his administration. Aided by his deputy, Manish Sisodia, who has been in jail since last February in connection with the same investigation that has ensnared his boss, Mr Kejriwal turned the capital's failing education system around. It is now regarded as one of the country's best. He also improved health care, particularly for Delhi's poorest.

His anti-graft credentials have made Mr Kejriwal a thorn in the side of Mr Modi, who is loth to see an opponent project an aura of incorruptibility. The BJP has also stepped up its hounding of other parts of the opposition, as the election draws closer. Mr Modi has had success painting politicians from the long-established Congress Party—with which Mr Kejriwal's party has allied—as corrupt,

elitist and out of touch. Mr Kejriwal, a conservative, technocratic upstart, is harder to tar with the same brush.

The winners of this week's quiz

Thank you to everyone who took part in this week's quiz. The winners, chosen at random, were:

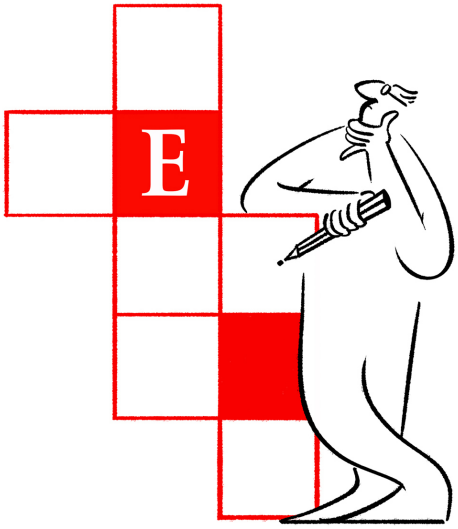
Rik Mulder, Hilversum, The Netherlands
Tetsuyuki Maruyama, Ito, Japan
Emil Skodon, Washington DC, America

They all gave the correct answers of Joseph Smith, sunset clause, The Phantom Menace, the Orient Express, and cats. The theme is Andrew Lloyd Webber musicals: Joseph and the Amazing Technicolour Dreamcoat, Sunset Boulevard, The Phantom of the Opera, Starlight Express and Cats.

The questions were:

Monday: Who was the founder of Mormonism? He published the Book of Mormon in 1830
Tuesday: What is the usual term for a provision in a bill that provides for a law to expire after a certain date?

Wednesday: What was the name of the first prequel in the Star Wars movie series, released in 1999?
Thursday: What was the name of the luxury train service that ran from Paris to Istanbul?
Friday: Abyssinian, Burmese and Persian are all types of which creature?



Weekly crossword

Our crossword has two sets of clues, one for seasoned cruciverbalists and the other for less experienced solvers. Both give the same answers, all of which feature in articles in this week's edition of *The Economist*:

Cryptic clues

1 *down* Awful cataract in unforgiving location (10)

1 *across* Saying a bit of Dickens takes a long time (5)

2 *across* Hazard in bazaar is known (4)

3 *across* Almost completely inadequate record (5)

Factual clues

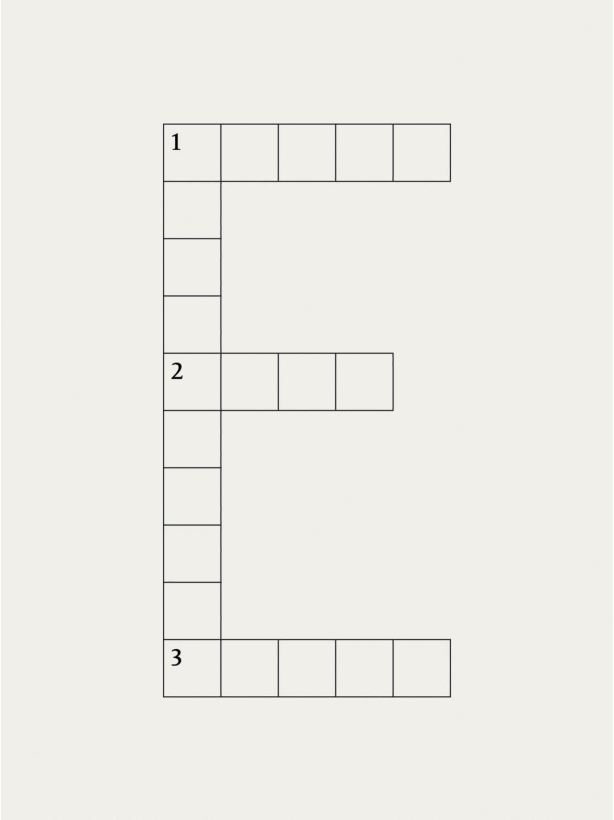
1 *down* Earth's largest refrigerator (10)

1 *across* What "all models are wrong" might be for statisticians (5)

2 *across* What Europe is trying to minimise from China (4)

3 *across* Beyoncé's "Cowboy Carter", for example (5)

Email all four answers, along with your home city and country, by 9am GMT on Monday to . We will pick randomly from those with the right answers and crown three winners in next week's edition.



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